

lucky addicts go to jail or rehab,” he’d said. “Because then they have to stop.” I don’t fully agree with that statement, but I understand what he meant by it.

On the other hand, my fellow interns were also “enabled” to thrive by *their* relatives of a certain socioeconomic class—likely much more so than my grandmother’s bailout of one month’s rent. Part of me thinks I should have gone home and learned a hard lesson. The other part is glad I was there to represent non-rich kids at internships. Peter Sterne, who created the popular transparency website Who Pays Interns? has observed that not paying interns creates a racial and economic barrier to the jobs later available.

Sterne, a Columbia University graduate, was inspired by Manjula Martin’s transparency site, Who Pays Writers? He went looking for a similar site that would tell him what internships were worth applying for if you were a lower-income person. When he couldn’t find one, he made his own. I asked if the companies cared that he was consolidating the information into a shaming website, and Sterne said no. They remarkably don’t see a problem with offering unpaid internships. They feel untouchable in this arena: Have your little website! It won’t change the number of people who apply here! We have the power!

“Because all or most prestigious media internships are not paid, it weeds out the working class,” Sterne said. This results in interns and future employees “who are wealthy and middle class and overwhelmingly white.” “If you don’t pay your interns,” he continued, “that is at odds with this desire to increase diversity.”

Eisenbrey of the Economic Policy Institute echoes my experience by pointing out that unpaid interns still have to “dress professionally, and pay for transportation. If you’re not from at least the middle class, maybe the upper middle class, forget it,” he said.

This was also the experience of Kayla Chenault, a 24-year-old African American graduate student at Eastern Michigan University who did three unpaid internships during her graduate and undergraduate education. When I interviewed her in the of summer 2017, she was doing an internship and working two jobs. “A lot of doubling up on having work and then